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Volume XXXIII Number 29; For the week July 15-21, 2008, released on July 14

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Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi

Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (U.P.) 201301;

Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and

Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080;

e-mail: ircare@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-2444423-6; Fax: 24444358; Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to

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India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007. (Haryana);

A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, district Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu); and

at Plot No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra).

Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.

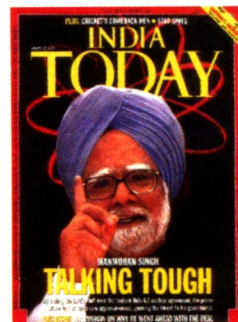
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Prime Minister Manmohan Singh never looked happy on the job. Who could blame him? Dominated and dictated to by Sonia Gandhi, hamstrung by ideologically inflexible allies like the Left parties, a target of constant backbiting by his senior colleagues, Manmohan has carried the can for all the ills of his government—whether it is the slow pace of economic reforms or the stuttering nuclear deal.

At one stage, it appeared that India's nuclear deal with the United States would become Manmohan's nemesis as well as the leitmotif for his prime ministership. A pact of great promise would end up in limbo because, like its prime minister, India was unable to take a stand and deliver on a promise. Last August, Manmohan appeared to defy the Left's threats of withdrawing support to the UPA by saying, "so be it". He later tempered his comments saying the UPA was not a "one-issue government". His party appeared unwilling to risk aggravating the Left and going to early polls. The deal and with it Manmohan's hopes of leaving a lasting legacy as prime minister, was as good as dead.

But with time running out on India and his deal, Manmohan has now pulled one final rabbit out of his hat. The one nobody imagined he would be able to. He has made a bold political gamble. He is attempting to save both the deal and his government. The Left's bluff has been called and in doing so, their threat has been neutralised. The Congress has even been convinced to do deals with much-despised adversaries like Amar Singh and Mulayam Singh to keep the UPA alive. It is one thing to try to do business with the CPI(M) whose politics is rooted in ideology.



Our August 2007 issue

It is quite another to take on board allies who could demand a price for their loyalty every week. With all the horse trading that is bound to follow, I am sure the coming weeks will reveal the ugly underbelly of Indian politics once again.

Our cover story this week is a wide-ranging analysis of the political turbulence caused by the prime minister's determination to stick to his stance on the nuclear deal. Editor Prabhu Chawla and our political bureaus across the country pooled in to bring you the complete picture of where the Government, its allies and their adversaries stand today.

Every prime minister is eventually judged by one deed, which is his signature and what he will be remembered for in history. Rajiv Gandhi pushed India into entering the computer age. Narasimha Rao will always be linked to liberalisation and Atal Bihari Vajpayee will always have Pokhran II. After all, leadership is all about rising above daily political rhetoric and immediate political gain to serve the long-term interests of the nation.

I believe the nuclear deal is of great benefit to the country and if Prime Minister Manmohan Singh can pull it off, the nation should cheer. And he should finally look a happier man.

(Aroon Purie)